

Gourmet

"Pilot"

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COLD OPEN

EXT. OUTSIDE OF THURSDAYS IN TIMES SQUARE - ESTABLISHING

A neon sign reads **"Welcome to Thursdays! Where Every Weekend Is A Four Day Weekend"**.

INT. THURSDAYS - KITCHEN - NIGHT

COOKS slink past each other in the cramped environment and perform at their stations. Flames on high, knives slice, fryer baskets get dunked, and pans sizzle with subpar food.

BRANDON MANK (29), a chubby white guy with baggy eyes and a half-finished sleeve, works a flat top.

BRANDON

I honestly don't give a shit.

EDDIE BURGOS (27), an upbeat, fast-talking Latino, and Brandon's best friend, cooks a steak on the grill.

EDDIE

Bro, what?! A famous food host chick drunkenly drops her vibrator in my back seat and you don't think that shit's hilarious?

BRANDON

Well, that part's amazing.

Brandon flips one of the many burgers in front of him.

EDDIE

Thank you.

BRANDON

I would like to see it.

EDDIE

Got it in my bag.

NATASHA (24), a Black woman with her Thursday's suspenders dangling on each side, stares at her phone as she sits on a counter nearby.

NATASHA

You should DM her and ask for a reward.

MAX (31), a permanently stoned trans woman with chicken tenders in her pocket, lifts a large bag of potato skins.

MAX

Maybe send her a ransom letter with,
like, the magazine clippings and
whatnot.

Max pours the bag into a fryer basket.

EDDIE

That's a good ass idea!

BRANDON

(chuckles)

Include a picture of it blindfolded
and you're good to go.

Thursday's manager RINALDO (42), a Frenchman with a permanent stick up his ass, barges in and LAUNCHES a menu in Brandon's direction. Brandon casually dodges it.

RINALDO

Where's table eight?! They're getting
restless. Fucking animals.

BRANDON

Two minutes.

RINALDO

(to Natasha)

Always with the fucking phone and your
Tic Tac! Get back out there before I
throw that thing into the fryer!

Rinaldo walks to the freezer area. Natasha rolls her eyes, puts her suspenders back on, flips Rinaldo off, and heads out of the kitchen.

Brandon spoons a glob of butter onto the flat top. Rinaldo comes in with an ice cream cake and plops it next to Brandon.

RINALDO(CONT'D)

Bon-appetite.

Rinaldo leaves.

BRANDON

It's just... trying to construct a
meal out of some canned tuna, squid
ink, and a bull testicle? What kind of
(MORE)

BRANDON (CONT'D)
chef would subject themselves to that
kind of nonsense?

Brandon grabs a handful of sliced onions and peppers from a
tray and tosses them in the butter next to the burgers.

MAX
I like it when they start sobbing over
soggy french toast.
(chuckling)
Then they tell us a story about how
they had a hard upbringing.
(cracking up)
What's the correlation?

Max eats some onion rings.

EDDIE
For that cash prize? I'd cook up some
gizzards any day, bro.

Rinaldo pops his head in the window.

RINALDO
Brandon! The swine at table eight are
about to riot!

Brandon takes a burger patty and puts it on a soggy bun with
wilted lettuce, a sad tomato, and a limp pickle.

BRANDON
Yea, well. If I ever stoop that low in
my career, you have my permission to
give me a swift kick in the nads.

Brandon grabs the charred steak from Eddie. Max brings over
potato skins. Everything, including the cake, goes on one
tray and onto the window.

BRANDON (CONT'D)
One double beef birthday bonanza with
trip-fried tater skins and a side of
fun... UP!

END COLD OPEN

ACT ONE

INT. THURSDAYS - KITCHEN - NIGHT

A clock shows One AM. Brandon, Eddie, and Max finish cleaning their stations. Natasha goes around and hands the staff crumpled-up tips. Brandon holds up a twenty and two singles.

BRANDON

Do you think Lacy will resent me when she realizes that all of her clothing comes from a thrift store?

EDDIE

(shrugging)

Macklemore made it work.

Natasha holds up her phone in the selfie position.

NATASHA

(into phone)

What's up, Tashy Tots! Nights almost over. It was a long one, but luckily, I have my temperpedic orthopedics on to get me through the night. Smash the link in the description if you want to walk on a cloud.

Max CHUCKLES as she breaks up weed onto a dollar bill.

BRANDON

People actually pay you to just be a person and wear their shit all the time?

NATASHA

Pretty much. By the way, I noticed that you stopped liking my posts. I need those likes to keep up with the algorithms. You're fuckin' with my revenue.

BRANDON

Eh, I'm over the whole social media thing. It's gone off the rails since Myspace Tom.

MAX

I always wondered what he was writing on that whiteboard.

Rinaldo walks in smoking a cigarette.

RINALDO

I swear to Christ. Rats. Rats everywhere. I put cheese on traps. They're garbage. They have themselves a feast and fuck off. This place must be spotless. You hear me?! SPOTLESS!

Rinaldo launches rat poison in the group's direction. Brandon snatches it out of the air. Rinaldo leaves.

BRANDON

That's always a good thing to toss around an eating establishment.

NATASHA

(to Brandon)

I don't know how you put up with that shit for six years. I'm struggling to hang on after eight months.

EDDIE

Easy.

Eddie takes a plastic squeeze bottle from the dressing station and squirts some in his mouth. Natasha looks disgusted.

EDDIE (CONT'D)

(to Natasha)

V-O. Stands for Vodka.

Brandon grabs the squeeze bottle and does the same.

BRANDON

He's got Vegetable Oil somewhere in here too.

EDDIE

Some days are better than others.

NATASHA

Ok, well, whenever you're done sippin' condiments, some of my girlfriends are at O'Shea's if you guys are down.

EDDIE

HELL yes.

BRANDON
Nah, I should probably head home.
Gotta put this cash into the painfully
empty savings jar.

Max pulls from a joint and hands it to Brandon.

MAX
(holding in smoke)
Very admirable.

Brandon takes a pull from the joint.

BRANDON
Plus, Mom's on these new meds, so
she's been less coherent than normal.
Lacy's been taking advantage and
devouring Chip Ahoy by the sleeve.

EDDIE
I don't know why you keep that shit in
the house, bro. Sugar addiction's no
joke.

NATASHA
(to Eddie)
My friend wants to know if you have
any blow.

EDDIE
Psh. Damn right I do.

Eddie whips out a large bag. Brandon stares at it for a beat.

BRANDON
Eh. I'll come for one drink.

INT. OSHEA'S PUB - NIGHT

REQUIEM FOR A DREAM TYPE OF MONTAGE:

- Brandon, Eddie, Max, and Natasha walk in.
- Key bumps of coke in the corner.
- Multiple shots taken and beers consumed.
- Chicken and rice devoured by the halal cart.
- Brandon arrives at the Staten Island ferry terminal.

INT. STATEN ISLAND FERRY - NIGHT

Brandon grips a Fosters Beer and stares at his empty wallet with glassy eyes. As he puffs on his Juul, A FERRY WORKER walks by.

FERRY WORKER

You can't smoke that on here.

BRANDON

Oh sh-- Sorry.

Brandon wafts the smoke away. The Ferry Worker pulls out a cigarette, lights it, and walks away shaking his head.

FERRY WORKER(O.S)

Some people.

Brandon scrolls through his phone. He sees the Instagram app, hesitates, and signs in.

Across the way, a BEARDED MAN walks with a large box. He carefully places it on the floor and stands on top.

BEARDED MAN

Brothers and sisters of the four-thirty ferry. We find ourselves once again on this floating death trap. Back and forth. Going nowhere fast.

Brandon stops at a post of a restaurant's grand opening.

BEARDED MAN(CONT'D)

Time slips. A new face appears as an old one dies. We see this every day, enyet we still crawl out of bed and walk these streets with the rest of the yawning and the baggy-eyed.

Brandon clicks on the profile and scrolls down seeing all of these amazing accomplishments.

BEARDED MAN(CONT'D)

We struggle each day and convince ourselves that change will come without the actual pursuit of change.

Brandon's creeping leads up to a picture of him and his old friend CHRIS holding their degrees in their chef uniforms.

BEARDED MAN(CONT'D)
To break free of the monotony, we must
look in the mirror and stare into the
eyes of the creature who holds us
back.

The caption reads "**Lookin' like we made it to the top of the class! Would've never made it through without this guy**".

BEARDED MAN(CONT'D)
Our paths are our own... What will you
choose?

Brandon stares at the picture. The FERRY CAPTAIN makes an
announcement.

FERRY CAPTAIN(O.S)
We are now docking. Please make your
way off the ferry.

Brandon locks his phone and puts it in his pocket. He walks
over to the Bearded Man.

BRANDON
Hey, Phil.

BEARDED MAN AKA PHIL
Hey, Brandon. What did you think?

BRANDON
A bit preachy. Better than your
vaccination rant though.

INT. BRANDON'S MOM'S HOUSE - NIGHT

Brandon walks in and sees his MOM passed out on the couch
with a half-finished glass of wine, an empty wine bottle, and
a cigarette cherry still lit in the ashtray. The only light
in the room comes from The Food Network across the couch.

Brandon crumbles up a receipt from his pocket and tosses it
at her. No response. He puts the cigarette out and stumbles
downstairs.

INT. BRANDON'S ROOM - NEXT MORNING

A minimalist room. Two single beds, a dresser with some beer
bottles, toys, and random knick-knacks. Clothes sprawled
across the floor, including Brandon's uniform.

The two beds sit across from each other. One has an old Lion King bedspread. The other has Brandon laying face down in his boxers. Brandon's daughter, LACY (5), an adorable half-Japanese girl with a short black bob still disheveled from the night before, jumps on his bed.

LACY

It's breakfast time! It's breakfast time! B-R-E-A-F-

Brandon peels open his bloodshot eyes.

BRANDON

(groggy)

Fuuuuu--

LACY

--Hey! That's a bad word!--

Lacy stops jumping. Brandon slowly perches himself up.

BRANDON

--uuunky monkey butt. You know, you should really... It's rude to cut someone off while they're speaking.

Lacy LAUGHS and continues to jump. Brandon rubs his eyes.

BRANDON

I would really appreciate it if you just. Please don't do that anymore.

(yawns)

What do you want for breakfast?

LACY

Peewee special!

BRANDON

Peewee special? You got it. Start the prep, sous chef.

LACY

Ok!

Lacy rips the pillow from Brandon's bed, bashes him with it, and runs out of the room LAUGHING. Brandon sits there with the pillow over his face.

BRANDON

(whispers)

Fuck.

INT. BASEMENT KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Brandon makes his way into the kitchen. He grabs orange juice from the fridge, sniffs it, shrugs, and gulps it down.

As juice dribbles down Brandon's shirt, Lacy grabs the eggs and bacon from the fridge and places them on the counter. Brandon puts the juice back in the fridge and hands the milk to Lacy.

BRANDON

Ok, grab me a pan and place it on the stove. Then I need you to whisk some eggs, fry up some bacon, and julienne some fruit. Got that, chef?

Lacy stares at him with her mouth agape.

BRANDON(CONT'D)

Or you could go upstairs and watch TV until I'm done.

LACY

Yes, chef!

She salutes him and runs upstairs.

BRANDON

And ask Grandma if she wants anything!

Brandon wipes his mouth and takes a deep breath.

BREAKFAST SEQUENCE:

- He throws some flour, milk, and eggs into a large bowl.
- He dollops spoon fulls of pancake mix and spreads them evenly on the pan, creating perfect circles.
- He peels off slices of bacon, places them on a sheet pan, and into the oven.
- He cracks an egg into a pan with one hand while flipping pancakes with the other.
- He vomits in the trash can nearby.
- His hand slightly shakes as he slices strawberries.
- He shakes up a can of whipped cream, sprays some onto the plate and into his mouth.

END OF SEQUENCE

Brandon steps aside and soaks up his masterpiece. It's a giant smiley face with all the fixin's.

BRANDON
Hey, Lace! Breakky ready!

Beat.

LACY(O.S)
Uh, ok!

BRANDON
Did you ask Grandma!?

LACY
She's still sleeping!

INT. LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Lacy's sitting on top of her Grandma. She's watching Food Network. Brandon walks upstairs with a dish towel over his shoulder.

BRANDON
(chuckles)
Lacy. Please don't sit on Grandma.
Food's on the table downstairs.

Lacy walks toward the stairs with her eyes glued to the TV.

BRANDON(CONT'D)
Get it while it's hot!

Brandon whips Lacy in the butt with the dishtowel. Lacy LAUGHS and scurries downstairs. Brandon looks over.

BRANDON(CONT'D)
C'mon, Ma. I know hangovers get worse
with age, but this is absurd.

No response. He walks over to her, CHUCKLES, and rips a fart in her face. He LAUGHS. She still doesn't respond. His smile slowly fades. She's not breathing.

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

INT. FUNERAL PARLOR - DAY

The room is half empty. Lacy plays with a distant relative as Brandon sits on a chair in his hand-me-down black suit. His UNCLE GEORGE sits next to him.

UNCLE GEORGE

--And the traffic on I-95. Psh! Forget about it. That's why I took exit 34, so I could cut around the back an--

BRANDON

--Uncle. Uncle George. I'm sorry. I just. I don't care.

UNCLE GEORGE

Right. You're in mourning. I understand. We'll catch up later.

Uncle George pats Brandon's knee and walks away. Eddie walks into the room and hustles over to Brandon, a little out of breath.

EDDIE

Hey, bro.

BRANDON

Hey, man. Thanks for coming.

EDDIE

Of course.

(looking around)

No, uh. No meat platter or anything?

BRANDON

People don't really crave deli meats with an open casket across the room.

EDDIE

Damn. How's Lacy?

BRANDON

Ok, I guess. That reminds me, you know any babysitters?

EDDIE

(sniffs)

Me? Nah. So, real quick. Remember how you said "I owe you one" when I

(MORE)

EDDIE (CONT'D)
covered your shift yesterday?

BRANDON
... Yes.

EDDIE
(hesitant)
Right, well. I. I could use that
owing. With some covering of my shift.
For tonight.

Beat.

BRANDON
We're at my Mom's wake, dude.

EDDIE
I know, I just. Sorry for your loss,
by the way, bro.

Brandon nods.

EDDIE (CONT'D)
I was supposed to go on this Hinge
date last night, but I had to bail to
cover you, so--

BRANDON
Alright, alright. I'll do it. I could
use the money right now anyway.

EDDIE
Thank you! You're the man!

Eddie slaps Brandon on the back and pops up.

EDDIE (CONT'D)
(talking fast)
It actually works out, bro. I got this
new body wash. Smells like confidence
and man musk with a hint of petunias.
Gonna wash up, trim up, and fluff up.
Maybe I sho--

BRANDON
--Jesus, are you...
(whispers)
Are you coked up right now?

EDDIE

What? Yea, a bit. Why? Want some?

BRANDON

I mean...

(sighs)

Yea, a little now.

EDDIE

No worries, bro. I got you. I got a bag or 4 on me. I'll put one in a flower pot before I leave.

Eddie daps him up and fast walks away.

Brandon looks over at Lacy. She's playing with his old Power Ranger action figure. She looks at Brandon and smiles. He gives a half-smile back.

There's a loud CRASH. People GASP. Eddie stands by the flower displays, looks around and slowly backs away from the mess he just caused.

EDDIE

Uh. Is this... is this where you wanted the bouquet?

Eddie pets one of the garlands and runs out.

INT. THURSDAYS - KITCHEN - NIGHT

Lacy reaches for a pot from the top shelf and knocks over a stack of pans. She WINCES. Brandon leaves his station to clean up the mess. Max CHUCKLES by the fryer.

BRANDON

Lacy, for the love of God.

LACY

Sorry. I wanted to be sous chef.

MAX

She'd be better than most of the staff here.

BRANDON

(to Lacy)

What happened to the fun corner?

ANGLE ON: Dirty corner of the kitchen with a milk crate, a cracked iPad, and a coloring book.

LACY
(disgusted)
It smells weird.

MAX
She's not wrong.

BRANDON
(to Lacy)
Yea, well. Dealing with foul smells is one of the many things a sous chef has to deal with. Another is listening to the head chef so he doesn't get in trouble with the, uh. Header. Chef.

Lacy GROANS, takes a seat in the corner and puts her headphones on.

MAX
Hey, head chef.

BRANDON
Yea?

MAX
Your food's on fire.

Brandon gets hit with a waft of black smoke.

BRANDON
Oh, sh--

Brandon rushes over to the grill with a fire extinguisher. He loses control and it sprays all over.

LACY
It's snowing!

Brandon turns it off and stares at the mess.

MAX
Eh, don't worry about it. I burnt the fries too. My mom didn't even die.

Brandon can't help but crack a smile. Rinaldo barges in.

RINALDO
What the HELL is happening?!

Rinaldo looks over at Brandon.

RINALDO(CONT'D)
God DAMMIT, Brandon. Get your ass out
of your ass!

BRANDON
I-I'm sorry. I just got a little
distracted. My kid wa--

RINALDO
--You think I give a damn?! She
shouldn't even be in my kitchen. This
isn't a daycare. Clean this up and get
the order ready right fucking now!

Rinaldo walks out. Brandon looks down at his powder-covered
shirt.

BRANDON
Max, you mind keeping an eye on her? I
gotta head to the bathroom.

Max gives Brandon a thumbs-up as she chews on burnt french
fries. Brandon walks out. Lacy takes off her headphones.

LACY
(worried)
Is my Daddy in trouble?

MAX
(chewing)
No, your Dad's just, uh. Doing a pee-
pee.

Beat.

MAX(CONT'D)
(chewing)
Hey, are scholastic book fairs still a
thing?

INT. THURSDAYS - BATHROOM - NIGHT

Brandon cleans himself off at the sink. He SNIFFS and wipes
his nose. He still has some white residue under his nostril.

The door opens. Brandon looks over to see RYAN, a hipster
type with a beard and Oakleys on the back of his head, doing
the classic "director getting his shot" pose with his hands.

BRANDON
Uh. Can I help you?

RYAN
Yes. Yes, you can.

Ryan holds the pose, but switches eyes.

RYAN(CONT'D)
Would you happen to be the cook around here?

Brandon looks down at his grease-covered uniform that has "Thursday's" stitched over the chest.

BRANDON
What gave it away?

RYAN
HA! Sense of humor. Love it. Name's Ryan. Some people call me Ry. Sometimes pastrami on Ry. Whatever you're feeling in the moment.

BRANDON
I'm Br--

RYAN
--I'll just cut to the chase. I'm a producer for this web-based cooking show called "Sabotage", and you just... have this look to you. I don't know. I can't put my finger on it, but you seem like a perfect candidate.

BRANDON
Thanks, but I--

RYAN
--That and the other contestant dropped out recently and we shoot tomorrow afternoon.

BRANDON
Right, well--

RYAN
--Before you say anything. Just know there's also a ten thousand dollar cash prize and we have one of the hottest Food Network personalities hosting.

Brandon hesitates.

BRANDON

I-

RYAN

--Not "hot" as in sexy. Like. Hot as in she's very popular right now. Gotta keep reminding myself of how I word things.

(chuckles)

Strange times. Right?

Ryan looks at his phone.

RYAN(CONT'D)

Woah! Sorry. Totally forgot, I have this thing. Here's my card.

Ryan whips out a card from his chest pocket. It has his info and a black and white picture of him doing the director pose with his hands. Ryan places it on the sink.

RYAN(CONT'D)

Oh, looks like you got a little...

Ryan wipes coke residue off of Brandon's nostril. Brandon JERKS back.

BRANDON

Ah, what the f--

Ryan takes a look at his thumb and then SNIFFS it off.

RYAN

Shoot me a call ASAP, champ!

Ryan exits the bathroom. Brandon stands there, flabbergasted.

EXT. SUBURBS - DAY

Brandon and Lacy walk hand and hand down the sidewalk.

LACY

And. And then. The wizard was dancing with the elf. And the werewolf queen got jealous, so you know what she did? You know what she did? She ate him!

BRANDON

What the hell kind of shows are you watching?

Lacy brightens up.

LACY

Mommy!

FIONA (33), a Japanese-American woman with flour stains on her apron, meets Brandon and Lacy outside of her condo. Lacy runs over and gives Fiona a hug.

FIONA

How was work young lady?!

LACY

Great! Daddy was cooking and he--

BRANDON

I almost set the place on fire.

FIONA

Oh. Uh. Wow! Daddy sure knows how to keep things interesting! Bring your stuff inside. I made some macaroons.

Lacy GASPS and runs in.

BRANDON

Loved hanging with you too, Lace!

(to Fiona)

Damn. Coming home to some macaroons? All I'd get was a hot pocket sprinkled with cigarette ash.

FIONA

You know, you shouldn't cut her off like that.

BRANDON

Trust me, there are only so many hours in a day.

Brandon and Fiona walk to the stoop and take a seat.

MRS. PETERMAN (80s) waters her flowers next door. Brandon waves.

BRANDON

Hey, Mrs. Peterman! Those tulips are looking almost as beautiful as you!

MRS. PETERMAN

Blow it out your ass, Brandon.

BRANDON
Always the charmer.

FIONA
How'd it go with the lawyer? Get
anything good in the will?

BRANDON
Not much to leave. Just this eviction
notice... and her porcelain angel
collection.

FIONA
Nice. I'm sure there's a cat lady out
there waiting for you to drop those
bad boys on Ebay.

Brandon takes out his Juul, puffs it, and hands it to Fiona.

FIONA(CONT'D)
How... how are you?

BRANDON
Well. The last thing I said to her was
"we're out of pop tarts". And the next
morning, I farted on her corpse.

FIONA
I'm being serious.

BRANDON
I wish I was joking.

Fiona makes a "yeesh" face. Brandon stares ahead.

FIONA
Do you think you'll pick up a side
gig?

BRANDON
Not really sure what I'd do.

FIONA
Prostitution perhaps?

Brandon smiles. Fiona puffs the Juul and hands it to Brandon.

BRANDON
I've considered it. Actually, there
was this guy in the bathroom today--

FIONA

Wow, death really changes a man. Are you sore? I have some ointment if you need.

BRANDON

No, I'm uh. I'm good on the butthole cream.

FIONA

Ignoring the pain. Very professional.

BRANDON

He wanted me to be on some internet cooking show called "Sabotage". I found an article on it. Basically a *Chopped* ripoff. Bunch of nonsense.

FIONA

Uhh, that actually sounds pretty cool. Isn't there a cash prize for those things?

BRANDON

Yea, but... I mean. That's no guarantee. Plus, it's time I could be spending putting in extra shifts.

FIONA

I'm sorry, Brandon. That's just...

Fiona shakes her head.

FIONA(CONT'D)

You've spent years working under that assbat to stay on your feet until something bigger came along. Now the universe throws you a bone and you're just going to ignore it?

BRANDON

Some internet cooking show isn't the "bone" I was looking for. At least at Thursday's I'm--

FIONA

Comfortable.

Brandon gives Fiona a look.

BRANDON

I was going to say guaranteed pay.

FIONA

Look, I'm not forcing you to do anything you don't want to. I think it's just a pretty crappy message to send to our daughter.

Fiona gets up and walks towards the door.

BRANDON

And what message is that?!

Fiona turns around.

FIONA

That it's ok to just ignore something that takes you out of your comfort zone by acting like you're above it, but in reality, you're just fucking scared.

BRANDON

Yea, well--

Fiona goes inside and slams the door behind her.

BRANDON(CONT'D)

That language is, uh. Not the best message either!

Brandon hits his juul and rubs his eyes.

MRS. PETERMAN(O.S)

She's right.

Brandon looks over.

MRS. PETERMAN(CONT'D)

You're being a bit of a pussy.

END OF ACT TWO

ACT THREE

INT. ELEVATOR - DAY

Brandon stares ahead. He has a laminated pass around his neck. It reads "**SABOTAGE**". He takes a DEEP BREATH. The elevator doors open to reveal...

INT. PRODUCTION STUDIO - CONTINUOUS

Brandon walks out. Ryan spots him and fast walks over.

RYAN
(enthusiastic)
There he is!

Ryan aggressively puts his arm around Brandon's shoulder and moves him in the direction he wants him to go.

RYAN(CONT'D)
So glad you called. I was getting a
bit worried.

BRANDON
Yea, you mentioned that the
contestants get paid just for
participating, right?

RYAN
Uhhh, did I?

Brandon gives him a look of concern.

RYAN(CONT'D)
I'm just jerkin' your chain, man!
We'll get all of that sorted out
later. C'mon, let's meet the folks
you'll be sabotaging.

INT. PRODUCTION STUDIO - CRAFT SERVICES - CONTINUOUS

AARON (45), a nerdy type with large glasses, a weathered chef's uniform, and loose skin under his neck, nibbles on celery as he talks to CARA (25), whose extremely dark circled eyes dart back and forth through her unkempt hair. Ryan and Brandon approach.

RYAN
Hey, hey! Here's the last of the
bunch. You guys bond over some
Triscuits and fruit before you try and
(MORE)

RYAN (CONT'D)
rip each other's hearts out.
(chuckles)
Right?! Oh, gotta run.

Ryan points and nods in a direction where no one's standing.

AARON
Hi there. Name's Aaron.

BRANDON
Brandon.

They shake hands.

AARON
I was just discussing the personal
story I plan on telling during the
interviews with Cara here.

BRANDON
Personal story? I just... planned on
talking about what I cooked.

RYAN(O.S)
You're contractually obligated, bud!

BRANDON
Goddammit.

AARON
I'll be discussing my struggles with
food addiction. I was once a hefty
two-ninety. Got myself down to one-
eighty-five.

BRANDON
No shit, man. Good for you.

AARON
Yea, thanks.
(satisfied sigh)
Been a real journey, to say the least.

BRANDON
Really giving Bilbo Baggins a run for
his money.

Cara MUMBLES some incoherent nonsense.

BRANDON (CONT'D)
 Sorry, I didn't catch that.

CARA
 I LIKE DRUGS AND COOKING SAVED MY
 LIFE.

She grabs a handful of cheese and shoves it in her mouth.

BRANDON
 (nodding)
 Nice.

LISA, a woman covered in vomit stains and regret, walks over with a SCREAMING baby.

LISA
 Hi, I'm Lisa. Aarons wife.
 (Baby voice)
 And this here is Miranda!
 (to Brandon)
 Would you mind holding her while I
 speak with my husband?

BRANDON
 Wh- I'd really... rather no--

Lisa hands Miranda over to Brandon.

LISA
 --Thanks so much. We'll be right back.

BRANDON
 I. I don't.

INT. PRODUCTION STUDIO - BEHIND THE SET - CONTINUOUS

Lisa pushes a boom mic away from her face.

AARON
 They seem really nice.

LISA
 (sarcastic tone)
They seem really nice.
 (normal)
 Get that garbage out of your head
 right now.

AARON
 Uh.

LISA
How many of these things have you
dragged me to?

AARON
I don't know. Maybe about five or six?

LISA
Try eight. And how many have you won?
hmm?

AARON
Well. I never actually wo--

LISA
Exactly. It's pathetic, Aaron. Look at
me. Diapers aren't cheap, ok? All she
does is poop. It's insane. She barely
eats, but still. Poopy. Everywhere!

AARON
(sighs)
She really does.

LISA
I need you to win this. See those
people over there?

Lisa points in the direction of Brandon and Cara. Brandon
tries to put Miranda on the table, but she SCREAMS even
louder. He picks her back up.

LISA(CONT'D)
They are not your friends. You hear
me?

A PRODUCTION ASSISTANT walks behind Lisa and Aaron.

LISA(CONT'D)
DO YOU?!

Aaron JUMPS. The Production Assistant slowly backs away.

AARON
Y-Yes. I. I hear you.

LISA
Now. I wouldn't worry about the girl
with the dead eyes, but the one with
the cliché arm tattoos might pose a
problem. You need to take him down.

AARON
Well... I'll try my best.

LISA
Your best isn't good enough. Trust me.
You have to go for the jugular. I'm
talking overkill. Sabotage the fuck
out of him.

The Production Assistant awkwardly CLEARS HIS THROAT.

PRODUCTION ASSISTANT
They're ready for you on set.

INT. PRODUCTION STUDIO - SABOTAGE SET - MOMENTS LATER

Brandon, Aaron, and Cara look around. Three cooking stations topped with cooking tools, pots, and pans are spread down a line. Proteins, veggies, and spices are piled high in boxes.

Across from the stations is a pantry filled with any other food items they might need. A few fold-up tables are set up along the way.

JANET WATERS (30), the host of Sabotage, enters with a phone to her ear.

JANET
(into phone)
No. NO. I don't care how much. I
can't. Just. Pay him whatever he asked
for.

Janet aggressively pushes the end call button. She gathers herself and walks over to the stations.

JANET
Sorry about that. I recently left
my... something very important to me
in an Uber. The driver's being a bit
of an ass about it.

Brandon flashes a smile.

JANET(CONT'D)
Anyway. I'm Janet Waters. Did Ryan
explain the rules of the game to you
guys?

Aaron and Cara nod. Brandon looks around.

BRANDON
I actually didn't get filled in.

JANET
I'm sure you can just put it together
from the episodes you've seen.

BRANDON
Isn't this... a new sho--

A PRODUCER wearing a headset walks in.

PRODUCER
--Ok! Ready in five!

CUT TO:

Brandon, Aaron, and Cara are lined up at their stations.
Blinding lights and cameras everywhere. The JUDGES view from
afar with a large plastic shield in front of their table.

Janet SPEAKS into one of the cameras.

JANET
They have thirty minutes to prepare a
scrumptious meal with the items we've
given them. They also have access to
the pantry, but they might find it
won't be so easy to enter.

SABOTEURS line up near the pantry. The tables in front of
them are topped with different food items. They're all
wearing face shields.

JANET
Do these chefs have what it takes to
create some delicious delicacies over
the heat of the flames and, more
importantly, each other? Let's find
out.
(turns to the contestants)
Chef's ready?

Cara and Aaron nod. Brandon looks around, then nods.

JANET(CONT'D)
Good... because it's time to...
SABOTAGE.

The clock looming above their heads starts to count down. All
three spring into action. Brandon gets his pans in order and

turns the stove on. He chops up some shallots and onions then tosses them onto a sizzling pan.

As Brandon crushes garlic, Aaron runs over to Brandon's station. Brandon looks up at Aaron and back at the food. Aaron hovers over him.

BRANDON

You... you mind backing up a bit? You have this weird... odor.

Aaron looks over at Lisa in the far corner who's clenching her jaw and slowly nodding.

AARON

(whispers)

Sorry about this.

Aaron smacks his pan of ingredients onto the floor.

BRANDON

Dude, what the hell?!

JANET

Oh! Looks like chef Aaron strikes first. Let's see how chef Brandon retaliates.

AARON

Sabotaged!

Brandon pushes Aaron out of his way and runs over to the pantry. He gets belted by a tomato by one of the Saboteurs.

SABOTEUR

Try and KETCHUP!

BRANDON

Do you guys write your own material?

SABOTEUR

Got a list full of puns at the ready.

The Saboteur grabs radicchio.

SABOTEUR(CONT'D)

This challenge is about to get RADICCHIO!

He chucks it. Brandon shields himself from the rest of the products being launched his way and grabs the items he lost

from the pantry.

When Brandon returns, he sees that his knives are missing.

BRANDON(CONT'D)
What the f--

Brandon looks over at Aaron who's CHUCKLING to himself.
Brandon clenches his jaw and turns to one of the Saboteurs.

BRANDON(CONT'D)
Hey! Dick head!

The Saboteur looks over and throws a bell pepper at Brandon.
Brandon ducks and it rocks Aaron in the face, knocking off his glasses in the process.

BRANDON(CONT'D)
Did that pepper happen to ring your bells?

SABOTEUR(O.S)
Stick to cooking, pal.

JANET
Woah! Chef Brandon uses some crude language to get under one of our saboteur's skins, letting him do the dirty work. Very clever.

Aaron shakes it off and picks up his glasses.

JANET(CONT'D)
It would appear that these two chefs have it out for each other, while Chef Cara's just... well, she's sabotaging herself.

Cara's pan goes up in flames. She realizes this right after the cream sauce she was blending splatters everywhere.

JANET(CONT'D)
Looks like she could use some Wonder Wipes.

GRAPHIC: Wonder Wipes logo of a monkey in a superhero costume with it's ass out holding a glowing wipe in the air.

CUT TO:

The clock's down to the last two minutes. The stations are a

mess. All of the contestants are covered in food and they're constantly looking around as they plate.

JANET(CONT'D)

These contestants have been slicing, dicing, and disrupting throughout the competition. They now have TWO MINUTES left! Get the food on the plate before your competitor destroys it!

Brandon wipes his plate down.

JANET(CONT'D)

Chef Brandon's almost finished plating, but... what's this?! It would appear he's completely neglected our surprise ingredient!

Brandon overhears Janet. He looks around.

BRANDON

What the hell are you talking about?

JANET

You've gotta do it now. Not... ladle.

Janet WINKS at Brandon. Brandon grabs the ladle at his station. On it, in tiny print, reads: "**Feelin' zesty! Make sure to add some citrus zest to your plate**".

BRANDON

Oh, Christ!

Brandon dodges produce as he runs to the pantry.

Chef Cara finishes up her hideous plate. She looks over at Brandon's masterpiece.

Brandon looks around frantically, spots a basket of oranges, and grabs one. Aaron stands before Brandon and his station.

AARON

I was on the O-line back in my college days... good luck.

Brandon looks at Aaron and the winding clock. He notices the mess under Aaron's feet.

JANET

One minute left, chefs!

Brandon takes a DEEP BREATH and charges Aaron. He acts as if he's going to bash into him, but JUKES instead. Aaron slips and heaves out an odd noise as he hits the ground hard. Lisa throws her hands in the air.

JANET

Ten seconds!

Brandon quickly zests the orange over the plates.

JANET(CONT'D)

Three... Two... One... FINITO. Step away from the plates.

Brandon SMILES (actually enjoying himself?!) and wipes the sweat from his brow. Aaron lays on the floor making a disturbing GUTTERAL NOISE.

BRANDON

You good?

AARON

Y-yea... I think so. Just. Give me a minute.

CUT TO:

The three chefs stand before the judges. JUDGE MIKE, JUDGE AMY, and JUDGE PHIL. They take their face shields off and look at the dishes in front of them. Cara steps forward.

CARA

Uh. It's a. I made you guys some.
Chipped beef. Sandwiches.

JUDGE MIKE

Well, Chef Cara. Just by looking at it, I can tell it... it won't be very good.

JUDGE AMY

Agreed.

JUDGE PHIL

Only one way to find out.

They all take a bite. Judge Amy GAGS and spits it out.

JUDGE PHIL

Yea. I agree with my fellow judge.
This tastes like a fried asshole.

JANET

Wow. Ok, well. Judges, next up is Chef Brandon.

Brandon steps forward.

BRANDON

So I made you guys braised duck breast with a side of roasted carrots over a balsamic fig reduction.

JUDGE MIKE

I have to say, Chef Brandon. I'm extremely impressed. To make this in the amount of time that you had with Chef Aaron trying his best to take you down is quite the feat.

They all take a bite. They're overjoyed.

JUDGE AMY

This. Chef Brandon. Wh-where did you say you worked again?

BRANDON

Uh. Thursdays. Over on Broadway.

JUDGE AMY

That's insane. This. THIS is insane. One of the best things I've ever put in my mouth.

Judge Phil SNICKERS. Judge Amy sneers at him.

JUDGE MIKE

I have to say, Brandon. I don't know what you're doing working there. You need to--

Judge Mike's stomach GURGLES.

JUDGE MIKE (CONT'D)

Huh. Sorry about that. Um. As I was sa--

All of the judges hold their stomachs. They don't look well.

BRANDON

Is... everything ok?

JUDGE MIKE

You mighta undercooked the du--

Judge Amy PROJECTILE VOMITS across the table.

LISA(O.S)

Ha!

JANET

What the hell did you feed them?

BRANDON

I-I just used whatever was in the pantry!

(to Aaron)

What did you do with my plate?!

AARON

Me?! I'm all about some hijinx, but I wouldn't poison someone!

Judge Mike runs away from the table, but pukes in the process. Cara smiles and GIGGLES. Brandon looks over at her.

CARA

Sabotaged!!!

Cara pulls out ipecac syrup. Ryan walks on set.

RYAN

Right, well, uh. That was a complete disaster. Start. Packing up, I guess. This--

LISA

Wait! Who won?!

RYAN

Well. Definitely not Brandon.

The judges all VIOLENTLY VOMIT in their respective corners.

RYAN(CONT'D)

They never tasted Aaron's, so...
Congrats Cara.

Cara GRINS and raises her arms in triumph.

INT. THURSDAYS - EVENING

Brandon walks in. A group of TEENS pass him. One notices

Brandon.

TEEN 1
Woah! You work here?

BRANDON
Uh. Yea.

TEEN 1
Damn. No wonder why I almost crapped
myself after my meal.

The teens LAUGH.

TEEN 2
No, you dope. You'd be barfing if he
made your food.

TEEN 1
True. True.
(to Brandon)
Can we get a pic?

Beat.

BRANDON
... No.

INT. THURSDAYS - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Eddie, Max, and Natasha are in the corner watching a video on
Natasha's phone. Brandon walks in and preps his station.

EDDIE
(laughing)
Yo, this shit's hilarious.

BRANDON
What?

Natasha shows Brandon her phone. It's "Sabotage".

BRANDON(CONT'D)
Wh- How did you?

Brandon walks over and takes Natasha's phone.

BRANDON(CONT'D)
I didn't think they'd let this air.

NATASHA

Well, it did. And you're trending.

The video has millions of views and the numbers climb.

MAX

How did you, like, not realize this?

BRANDON

I sort of wanted to forget about the whole experience. I haven't even looked at any social media.

Brandon opens his Instagram. He's got dozens of messages in his DM's from other TV/Internet producers in the Food Entertainment Industry.

The top one reads, "**Hey, would you be interested in coming in to try out for our show? Your food looked amazing and it would be great to get the ipecac guy on.**"

BRANDON (CONT'D)

Holy shit.

Eddie gives Brandon a swift kick in the nads.

END OF PILOT